

INTRODUCTION: RE-FRAMING “FAILURE”

- Conventionally, denied field access is viewed as an obstacle to overcome.
- This paper examines denied access to Chinese care robotics companies not as failure, but as a methodological and analytical resource.
- Systematic silence, declining interest, and non-response constitute important data about knowledge politics in the field.
- When refusal comes from power elites rather than marginalized groups, corporate silence protects hype and maintains the separation between frontstage narratives and backstage technical realities.

RESEARCH BACKGROUND & DESIGN

- Goal: To understand how different stakeholders imagine “good robotic care” in China.
- Method Approach: Drawing on Actor-Network Theory “follow the actor” (Latour, 2005), aiming to trace robots from labs to deployment settings (nursing homes/households).
- The Context: China is a rapidly growing robotics market, but the research environment is sensitive due to geopolitical competition and suspicion toward social science qualitative fieldwork.
- The Predicament: The ambitious design was entirely dependent on ethnographic field access, which was ultimately blocked.

A CHRONICLE OF BOUNDARY ENCOUNTERS

- Phase 1: Systematic Cold Emails
 - Targeted five leading industry players with detailed proposals emphasizing ethical commitments and academic nature.
 - Outcome: Five companies, zero replies.
- Phase 2: Indirect Insider Paths
 - Connected with an intern via LinkedIn based on shared student status.
 - Insider Leak: A prominent “star product” was internally considered to be “cheating investors’ money”, revealing a gap between frontstage narrative and backstage reality.
 - Outcome: Communication with higher-level directors faded into indefinite silence.
- Phase 3: Expanding Scope to Startups

WHEN SILENCE SPEAKS

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- Case A (The “Co-creation” Startup): A company promising user “co-creation” completely lost interest when learning the project was “social science research” requiring fieldwork.
- Case B (The Candid Manager): An overseas marketing manager shared privately that deployments were only for “promotional purposes” and that most care robots “mostly aren’t a solution yet”.
- Outcome: Candidness occurred only in private; formal access to the “backstage” remained blocked.

ANALYSIS: HYPE & BOUNDARY WORK

- Denied access is not just bureaucratic inaction; it is active boundary work utilized to maintain sociotechnical imaginaries.
- The Frontstage/Backstage Divide(Goffman, 1959):
 - Companies must maintain optimistic visions to attract investment and construct “acceptable futures”(De Togni et al. 2023).
 - This requires managing “who knows what”, separating hyped narratives for public consumption from the technical limitations known to engineers.
- Managing Observation: Social scientists are unwelcome audiences because they might see the cracks in the present reality, threatening the performative function of future-oriented hype(Borup et al., 2006).

POSITIONALITY AS GEOPOLITICS

- Boundary work is national as well as organizational; against a backdrop of US-China competition, foreign university affiliation is viewed as a potential security risk.
- Positionality is situational: Shared identity (e.g., fellow Chinese students abroad) facilitated private truth-telling but could not overcome organizational barriers to formal access.

CONCLUSION: FAILURE AS METHOD

- Refusal from power elites (tech companies) is an operation of knowledge politics.
- The “field” accessed was not one of robot manufacturing, but one constituted by silence, evasion, and careful boundary management.
- These experiences reveal how knowledge about robots is managed to maintain the imaginary system of care robotics; it is about what researchers are permitted to know.

FUTURE DIRECTIONS: ALTERNATIVE ENTRY POINTS

- Engaging former employees no longer bound by organizational loyalty.
- Analyzing public materials (patents, roadshows) for rhetorical gaps.
- Observing marginal spaces at industry conferences.
- “Reverse contact” through deployment sites like nursing homes.

